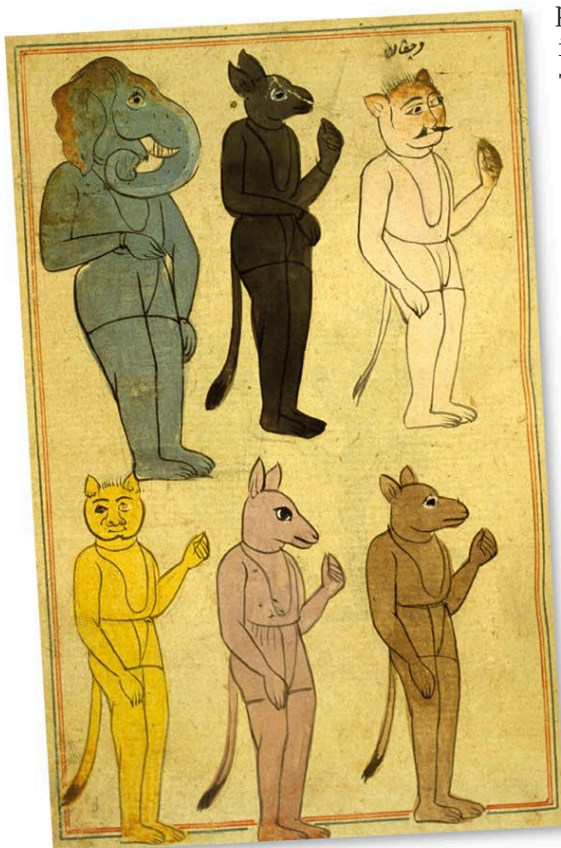


THE DIVINE AND THE WONDROUS

magic and early Islam

▼ Magical spirits

Jinns (genies) were shape-shifting spirits that pre-date Islam, but the Quran accepted them as part of God's creation. Most *jinns* were neither good nor evil, but a few were *shayatin*, dangerous demons, like the blue elephant below in this copy of Zakariyaal-Qazwini's 13th-century manuscript.



After Prophet Muhammad's death in 632, Islam spread out far from its beginnings among the Arab peoples. Wherever it spread, most people adopted Muslim beliefs, and followed the Quran. However, old customs did not instantly vanish, and while administration and scholarship became principally Islamic, ancient pre-Islamic magical practices continued across the empire.

Moreover, following Muhammad's injunction to "Seek knowledge everywhere, even if you have to go to China," Islamic society became a powerhouse of scholarship. The city of Baghdad was the center for translation of ancient works. Most texts were in Greek, but they also came from Persia, India, and China. Besides science and philosophy, works of ancient magic, including texts attributed to Hermes Trismegistus (see pp.134–135) and Zoroaster (see pp.30–31), reached Baghdad and the Islamic world.

Protection against demons

Muslims considered God all-powerful, but still believed that they needed his intervention to protect them from *shayatin* (dangerous ancient spirits).



◀ Solomonic earring

This decorative star probably alludes to the Seal of Solomon. God was said to have given Solomon the seal so he could control *jinns*.

The *shayatin* were a group of evil demons, including fallen angels and malicious *jinns* (genies). In the Quran they are identified as tempters of the mind, but for many people the *shayatin* were real and dangerous. The same was true of another belief that continued from early times—the evil eye: the curses and spells that made bad things happen.

Talismans and magic bowls

The Quran frowned upon the talismans of the pagan Arabs, but that did not stop early Muslims from calling upon their powers to ward off the *shayatin* and the evil eye. The concession made by followers of Islam was that talismans were inscribed with quotes from the Quran. Indeed, some might even be miniature Qurans. Solomon was known as both a prophet in the Quran and a magician of old, and his six-pointed star seal often appeared on talismans.

One particularly popular form of apotropaic (protective) magic, especially around the 12th century, was the magic bowl. Simple clay bowls were kept for healing all kinds of afflictions.

“... it was the disbelieving devils ... who taught mankind sorcery ... they do no harm to anyone with their sorcery, save by God's leave.”